



Incident handler's journal

Instructions

As you continue through this course, you may use this template to record your findings after completing an activity or to take notes on what you've learned about a specific tool or concept. You can also use this journal as a way to log the key takeaways about the different cybersecurity tools or concepts you encounter in this course.

Date: September 27, 2026	Entry: 1
Description	Documenting a cybersecurity incident: a phishing-initiated ransomware attack that disrupted business operations at a small health care clinic.
Tool(s) used	None.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. ● Who caused the incident? An organized group of unethical hackers known to target organizations in the healthcare and transportation industries. ● What happened? A ransomware attack encrypted the clinic's critical files, including patient medical records. The attackers left a ransom note demanding a large sum of money in exchange for the decryption key. ● When did the incident occur? On a Tuesday at approximately 9:00 a.m., when employees reported that they could not access their files. ● Where did the incident happen? At a small U.S. health care clinic specializing in primary-care services, affecting employees' computers and the company network. ● Why did the incident happen? The attackers sent targeted phishing emails containing a malicious attachment to several employees. Once downloaded, the attachment installed malware that gave the attackers access to the network, where they deployed the ransomware.
Additional notes	How could the clinic prevent an incident like this from happening again? Phishing awareness training, email attachment filtering, and regular offline backups would greatly reduce both the risk and the impact. Another question is whether the clinic should pay the ransom: paying does not guarantee the files will be recovered and may encourage further attacks. Because patient data was affected, the incident should also be reviewed for HIPAA breach-notification obligations.

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If you want to add more journal entries, please copy one of the tables above and paste it into the template to use for future entries.

Reflections/Notes: This entry reinforced how a single phishing email can escalate into an organization-wide ransomware incident. Clear documentation using the 5 W's makes it easier to understand the attack, communicate it to stakeholders, and plan preventive controls.
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